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200 Wins, Two Coaches, One Culture

After 200 wins and a 2020 state title, Erik Vanags and Jeff Hinebaugh step away from Mariemont boys soccer together. (dek option)

By Chase Beach

Written entirely by Claude in Chase's voice, for comparison with version two. Not a Chase version. 730 words.

On August 20, when Mariemont beat Ross 6-0, Erik Vanags got his 200th win as head coach, the most in Mariemont boys soccer history, and he didn't know it. "I think Lisa (Erik's wife) knew. I didn't know," he said. "She made sure to get a picture of Jeff and I."

That picture of Erik and Jeff Hinebaugh means a little more now. This fall is the last on the sideline for both of them.

The Ohio High School Athletic Association's boys soccer record book only lists coaches with 250 or more wins, and just 36 in state history have made it. Since starting as head coach in 2011, Erik has won more games a season (13.1) than any of the Cincinnati coaches in that record book. He won the Division III state title in 2020 with a 23-0 team, was Ohio's coach of the year in 2015 and 2020, and got win 210 on October 31, when Mariemont beat top-seeded Oakwood 3-0 in the district final.

In Mariemont, the only coaches in that air are Tom Crosby, with 215 wins in football, and Steve Peterson, with 203 in lacrosse. When I brought them up, Erik wouldn't hear it. "Those two guys, they are freaking legends in the game," he said. "I don't look at us as in that pantheon or category." That's Erik. It's always about the team.

It's also always about Jeff. Erik wouldn't do this story without him. "Everybody always calls me the head coach," Erik said. "I'm like, Jeff's been a part of every decision." Jeff has coached with the program for 23 years without taking a salary, and Erik asked me not to call him a volunteer. "Volunteer, you think, oh, it's part time," he said. "The day we lose at the end of the season, that night we're together planning the next season."

They hit it off in Erik's first preseason, when each of them, on his own, looked up the same opponent on an obscure soccer database. "We both were like, did we just become best friends?" Erik said. Jeff's version: "Step Brothers, 100% Step Brothers." Jeff is a selfless, happy go lucky guy, always encouraging and never negative, a lot like Erik. Sitting with them, you see they're on the same page as coaches and as people.

Ask them what it's all for, and it isn't the wins. "We'd love to tell you it's winning," Erik said. "It's really not." Jeff said what he'll remember is "you see these guys coming in as freshmen, and you watch them come up through. And when they leave, they're great young men." In all their years together, Jeff said, "I have never heard (Erik) talk about any kid as a kid he doesn't like."

His players carry it with them. Luke Brothers scored twice in the 2020 state final. "I always remember Erik, after the 2020 state win, saying, 'Don't let this be the defining point of your life,'" Brothers said. "I carry that with me for every new accomplishment or milestone." Quinn Budig, who graduated with me in 2011, put it this way: "Their passion for the game and belief in every athlete have helped countless players succeed on the field, but their greatest impact has been in shaping them into men of character off it."

I saw it in the classroom too. On the first day of my freshman year in 2007 (Erik's first year teaching), he taught history in what seemed to be an Irish or Scottish accent, and I knew it was going to be a fun year. He told me he swears every year he won't do it, and every year he does. He really cared about you as a person, not just your test score.

Jeff isn't going far. "I will stay involved with Mariemont soccer, just not as a coach," he said. "I'm always going to be a fan, a supporter." Erik thinks the program is in a great spot, with young coaches who "buy into the culture we've established, and of course, we want them to build their own."

Mariemont is a special place with special people, who not only live here but teach here and take the time to coach here.

When I asked Erik what he would say to every player he has coached, he said, "I love ya, and I hope you're doing well."